

Like IRC servers, there are plenty of XMPP server programs. We'll be using one called OpenFire. It's simple to use and one reason for this is that it uses its own internal database. This means that you don't have to setup a separate SQL database to store information on all your users. There's no need even to install a web server to control the features on the web interface.

Installation of OpenFire is also one of its great features. It comes in a ZIP file and requires no installation whatsoever. OpenFire can be downloaded from [www.igniterealtime.org](http://www.igniterealtime.org). Download the installation for your operating system. If you don't have a recent JRE (Java Runtime Environment) installed, then choose the larger download that comes packed with JRE. We'll be using the Windows version.

Unzip the file into a suitable folder on your hard drive, then run the \bin\openfire executable. This application is simply an interface for the service that runs in the background. Click on Start to start the server. Ensure that you have your firewall setup to give way to OpenFire. If you don't, users won't be able to connect to your server.

When you have OpenFire running, users using Jabber clients will be able to connect and register accounts on your server. To control the server, you need to access the web interface. Click on the Launch Admin button on the OpenFire application. The application is pre-installed, so the only steps remaining are the ones to configure the server.

The first step requires you



Selecting the kind of database for the users

to enter the language you will be using for the interface. The next step is the domain name for your server followed by the step for choosing the database type. If you have an SQL server

already, you can choose the standard database connection option. The embedded database uses an internal database and requires no further configuration. When the last steps are complete, it's recommended that you restart the server.

## Administrating the server

Once the server comes back up, we'll need to setup some of the features for the server. All of the tweaking of the server is to be done using the same web interface – this is accessed using your browser.

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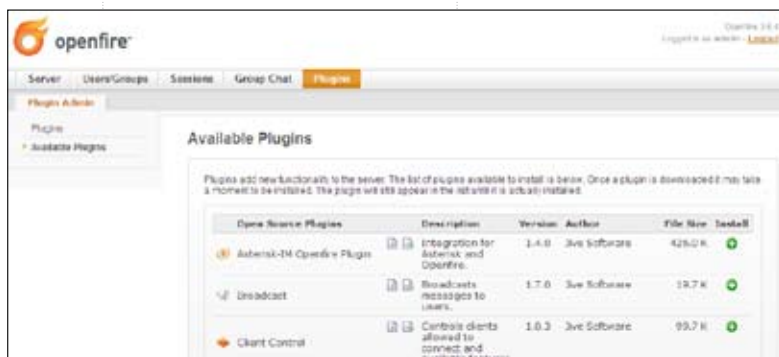
The default port for OpenFire is set to 9090, so the URL to access the interface is [http://your\\_IP\\_or\\_domain:9090](http://your_IP_or_domain:9090).

Login with the username admin and password admin. The interface is roughly split into five sections with sub menus within it.

**Server:** Everything to do with the OpenFire server is managed from this menu. Everything from updating the server to backing up the user database and setting up offline message storage can be done from here.

**Users/Groups:** User and group registration can be managed from here. If you disable open user registration, then the users and groups can be created by the administrator from this menu. So if you have a group of friends you only want on your server, you can add them from here.

**Sessions:** This menu



The list of plugins available on OpenFire

contains all the information about logged in users. The administrator can disconnect users and also send real-time alert messages from here.

**Group Chat:** The group chat menu allows conferences to be created. Group conferencing is something that most services have left disabled. Conferences are exactly like chat rooms on IRC. In this menu, existing conferences can be deleted and restrictions can be put on them so only certain authorized users can connect to it.

**Plugins:** The ability to add plugins is another interesting feature of OpenFire. The available plugins menu gives you a list of those available. Installing plugins is as simple as clicking the + icon next to the plugin that you want.

## Google Talk / ICQ / MSN / Yahoo through your own service!

One of the plugins that OpenFire has available is a bridge that lets a user connect to other instant messenger services. Next, click on Server > Gateways. Here, click the check boxes of the protocols that you want to enable. Click on Tests to see if the OpenFire server can communicate with the protocols. The permissions link allows you to choose if only users of a specific group can connect to the servers. The Options link has the server address and port. You might have to make changes for IRC to specify the servers you want to connect to. The registrations link on the left panel allows you to add new accounts. Click on Add Registration and enter the information for your accounts.

## Connecting to your Jabber server

The great thing about using your own open instant messaging chat service is that you allow users to use any of the clients available. Miranda and Pidgin are two free applications that support XMPP



Add gateways and registrations to OpenFire

and at the same time are also all-in-one messengers. XMPP's site has a big list of recommended clients – <http://xmpp.org/software/clients.shtml>.

Install one of the clients. We'll use Pidgin for now. Unlike other online messengers, XMPP allows users to create accounts directly through the client. If this is the first time you are running Pidgin, then you will see the Accounts window show up first. If you don't, click on Accounts > Manage accounts. Click the Add button.

Set the protocol to XMPP and enter a nickname that you want to create on the server. Enter the domain and the resource. Click on Add new account and then enter all the required data. Click OK. You will get a confirmation of the account creation.

Enable the account that you have created and you will be able to connect to the XMPP server. If you have set the server to use particular kinds of encrypted passwords or any changes to the ports, use the same settings for the client.